Xceptor

Statement of Work

AI-Forward Product Research & Strategy

Client: Xceptor Ltd
Scope: Full Xceptor Product Suite
Issued: April 2026
Version: 1.0 — Draft for Vendor Review
Owner: Sareena Brookshire, Xceptor

1. Background & Strategic Context

Xceptor operates in a financial data automation and reconciliation market that is being materially reshaped by advances in artificial intelligence. The pace of change — across both the competitive landscape and client expectations — requires Xceptor to ground its product strategy in current, high-quality insight rather than assumption.

This engagement is commissioned to accelerate that process. Xceptor is seeking an agency partner capable of combining AI-assisted research methodology with genuine strategic rigour to deliver a clear, evidence-based view of where the highest-value product opportunities exist across the Xceptor suite — and how those opportunities connect to measurable ARR growth.

Rather than a traditional 10-12 week research cycle, this brief targets a four-week engagement. Agencies should consider how they would achieve this timeline without sacrificing the quality of insight and strategic rigour required.

2. Engagement Objectives

This engagement should deliver against four interconnected objectives:

- Synthesise existing client signal — draw on Xceptor's CRM, support/success data, and internal documents to identify patterns, friction points, and unmet needs across the client base. This analysis should also surface which products or areas show the strongest signals of depth, risk, or opportunity — directly informing which parts of the suite warrant deeper client research and observation.
- Generate primary client insight — conduct rapid client discovery combining interviews and direct observation. This includes participating in key client delivery conversations or facilitating structured product walkthroughs to see how clients use the Xceptor suite in practice, not just how they describe it.
- Map strategic opportunities — produce a prioritised view of product opportunity areas across the full Xceptor suite, informed by client insight, market trends, and the impact of AI on the competitive landscape.
- Assess competitive position — provide an externally grounded view of where Xceptor stands relative to competitors and incumbents, identifying where to defend, where to differentiate, and where to double down across the product suite.
- Connect insight to commercial outcomes — all recommendations must articulate a credible path to ARR impact, framed in terms Xceptor's product and GTM teams can act on.

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Success is not a research report. It is a set of prioritised, commercially grounded strategic bets that the Xceptor product leadership team is ready to act on.

3. Scope of Work

The target engagement duration is four to six weeks. The total duration and the approach to achieving it are for the agency to propose, within that range.

Xceptor is not prescribing a methodology. Agencies should propose the approach they believe will most effectively deliver against the objectives in Section 2 and the required deliverables in Section 4. Proposals will be evaluated on the quality and credibility of the approach, not on adherence to a prescribed structure.

4. Deliverables

The following deliverables are required at the close of the engagement. Agencies may propose additional outputs but must commit to all items below.

Deliverable	Description
Client Insight Synthesis	A structured synthesis of findings from CRM/support data, internal Xceptor documentation, and primary client research. The initial data analysis should be used to identify which products require the deepest client investigation — primary research effort should be allocated accordingly, not spread evenly across the suite. Minimum 12-15 interviews. Organised by theme, not by client. Must distinguish between stated and latent needs. Includes a standalone section on behavioural observations from client sessions.
Strategic Opportunity Map	A prioritised map of product opportunity areas across the Xceptor suite, with supporting evidence for each. Should include a clear prioritisation rationale. Maximum ten opportunities, with top three highlighted.
Product Roadmap Implications	Specific recommendations for each priority opportunity area, articulated as directional inputs to the product roadmap. Each recommendation must include a narrative on ARR growth linkage.

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Stakeholder Readout Deck	A presentation deck (PowerPoint) for a 60-minute readout session with Xceptor product leadership. Must be structured to drive decisions, not just summarise findings.
Client Observation & Discovery Sessions	Structured observation of clients using the Xceptor product suite in context — either by participating in key client delivery conversations or through facilitated walkthroughs where clients demonstrate their specific workflows across the suite. The agency should propose how many sessions are required and how findings will be documented. A summary of behavioural observations and implications must be included as a standalone section within the Client Insight Synthesis deliverable.
Competitive & Market Landscape Analysis	An externally grounded view of how Xceptor compares to direct competitors and relevant incumbents across the product suite. Must assess where Xceptor has defensible advantage, where it is exposed, and where there are underexplored opportunities to double down. Should draw on publicly available intelligence, analyst coverage, and any competitive signals surfaced during client research. Findings must be integrated into the Strategic Opportunity Map and, where relevant, into the Product Roadmap Implications.

5. Proposed Timeline

The target engagement duration is four to six weeks. Agencies should propose a timeline within this range and provide clear rationale for the duration recommended.

Week	Phase & Focus	Key Milestones
Week 1	Discovery & Data Immersion	Kick-off workshop completed. CRM/support data analysed. Internal stakeholders interviewed. Research framework and interview guide signed off.
Week 2	Client Research Sprint	12-15 client interviews completed. Secondary research drafted. Initial themes emerging. Mid-sprint check-in held.

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Week 3	Synthesis & Insight Generation	Full insight synthesis complete. Strategic opportunity draft ready. Mid-point review with Xceptor held.
Week 4	Strategy & Readout	All deliverables finalised. Competitive analysis integrated. ARR linkage articulated. Stakeholder readout delivered.
Week 5	Client Observation & Competitive Analysis	Client observation sessions and product walkthroughs completed. Competitive and market landscape analysis complete. Findings integrated into synthesis and opportunity map. All inputs ready for final strategy week.
Week 6 (if required)	Contingency	Available if client observation or interview scheduling requires additional time. No new scope. Buffer should not be used to compensate for slow delivery in earlier phases.

Timeline note: Xceptor expects proposals within a four to six week range. Proposals outside this range must clearly explain the additional value delivered — we are not looking for more research, we are looking for sharper strategy.

6. Data & Access Requirements

Xceptor will provide the following inputs to support the engagement. Agencies should flag any additional data requirements in their proposal.

What Xceptor will provide

- CRM data export covering active and churned accounts, opportunity history, and deal notes (suitably anonymised or under NDA as required). Analysis of this data should be used to identify which products or areas warrant the deepest client research focus.
- Support and customer success logs, including ticket themes, renewal and expansion conversation notes, and CSM assessments.
- Facilitated introductions to 15-20 clients for research purposes. Xceptor will manage outreach; the agency should provide a briefing note for client participants.

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- Access to up to six internal stakeholders (product leadership, sales, customer success) for kick-off and mid-point sessions.
- Existing analyst reports, sales collateral, or competitive intelligence held internally — subject to NDA.
- Relevant internal documentation across the product suite — including product specs, roadmap materials, usage data, and any existing client feedback or NPS data — to enable the agency to identify, prior to primary research, which products require the deepest client investigation.

Agency responsibilities

- Signing a mutual NDA before data is shared.
- Storing and handling all Xceptor and client data in compliance with applicable data protection regulations.
- Obtaining informed consent from client interview participants and handling data accordingly.
- Returning or securely deleting all Xceptor data upon engagement completion.

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7. Governance & Ways of Working

This engagement is designed to be fast-moving. Governance should enable speed, not create bureaucracy.

- A single point of contact will be designated at Xceptor to manage day-to-day relationship and review.
- Check-in calls (maximum 30 minutes) to share progress, flag risks, and align on next steps.
- Mid-point review at the end of Week 2 — a 60-minute session to review emerging themes and adjust direction if needed.
- Explore need for onsite time in LDN and NYC with clients
- All deliverables should be shared as working drafts before final submission to allow for Xceptor input.
- The agency should flag scope changes, data access issues, or timeline risks immediately — not in the final week.
- Xceptor will aim to provide feedback within 48 hours of receiving draft deliverables.

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8. Assumptions & Exclusions

Assumptions

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- CRM and support data and product information will be available and in a structured format within three business days of engagement start.
- Xceptor will facilitate client interview introductions within the first five business days. Delays beyond five business days may be used to justify a timeline at the upper end of the four to six week range.
- Internal stakeholders will be available for the kick-off workshop in Week 1 and the mid-point review in Week 3.
- The agency has access to commercially appropriate AI tooling and does not require Xceptor to procure licences on its behalf.

Exclusions

- This engagement does not include product design, UX, or prototyping work.
- This engagement does not include implementation planning or execution of roadmap items.
- Market sizing analysis requiring primary quantitative research (survey-based) is out of scope unless the agency proposes AI-assisted secondary sizing as part of their methodology.
- Ongoing retainer or advisory support beyond the four-week sprint is not included in this SOW but may be discussed separately.

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9. How to Respond

Xceptor is looking for agencies with a proven track record in insight-to-strategy work and a clear, credible approach to delivering against the objectives set out in this document. Proposals should demonstrate strategic sharpness and domain credibility, not volume.

Proposal requirements

1. Team credentials: Identify the lead strategist and research lead who will work on this engagement. Provide brief biographies and examples of relevant prior work.
2. Proposed approach: Set out how you would structure and deliver this engagement to meet the objectives in Section 2 and deliver the required outputs in Section 4. Agencies are free to propose their own phasing, methodology, and ways of working.
3. Case studies: Provide two to three examples of similar engagements — insight-to-strategy work for B2B technology companies, ideally in financial services or data-intensive sectors. For each, describe the research approach, deliverables, and commercial outcomes achieved.
4. Timeline: Propose a specific timeline within the four to six week range and confirm it is achievable, with rationale for the duration recommended.

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5. Commercial proposal: Provide a fixed-fee proposal based on your proposed timeline within the four to six week range.
6. Timeline confirmation: Confirm that the four-week timeline is achievable or explain your recommended timeline with clear rationale.

Evaluation criteria

Proposals will be evaluated against the following criteria:

Criterion	Weight
Credibility and quality of the proposed approach	30%
Relevance of case studies and domain experience (B2B, FinTech, data automation)	25%
Quality and clarity of proposed approach	20%
Team seniority and direct involvement (not offshored to juniors)	15%
Commercial value and timeline confidence	10%

Proposals should be submitted to Sareena Brookshire (sareena.brookshire@xceptor.com) by the date communicated in the accompanying briefing email. Xceptor reserves the right to shortlist agencies and conduct a brief credentials presentation before awarding the engagement.

We are not looking for the largest agency or the most comprehensive response. We are looking for the sharpest thinking, the most credible methodology, and the team most likely to deliver clear strategic direction in four weeks.

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